Chapter 17 | Written solutions

Designing Reproducible Evaluations

These twelve solutions connect the question being asked to the unit counted, the cost of a mistake, and the uncertainty of a comparison. The same predictions can lead to different conclusions when the denominator or the decision cost changes. Small arrays make each step inspectable. These fixtures teach evaluation mechanics; they are not evidence about the quality of a deployed model.

1. Choose an evaluation unit

The short conversation has one correct check out of one. The long conversation has four correct checks out of five. Count all checks equally to get $(1 + 4)/(1 + 5) = 5/6 \approx 83.3\%$. The long conversation receives five times the weight.

Give each conversation equal weight by first computing its own accuracy: $(1 + 4/5)/2 = 0.9 = 90\%$. This answers how accurate the average conversation is. It still allows mistakes within a conversation. For complete-request success, give a conversation a 1 only if every check succeeds. The short conversation succeeds and the long one fails, giving $(1 + 0)/2 = 50\%$.

The same outcomes support three answers because the questions differ. If the promise is to handle the entire request correctly, the last measure is the one that directly checks that promise.

2. Compare two kinds of error

Treat UPDATE as positive. Of six real updates, A finds three and B finds five. Thus A misses three and B misses one. Of fourteen lookups, A falsely flags one and B falsely flags four, leaving thirteen and ten true negatives respectively.

Quantity	A	B
True positives	3	5
False negatives	3	1
False positives	1	4
True negatives	13	10
Accuracy	$16/20 = 0.80$	$15/20 = 0.75$
Precision	$3/4 = 0.75$	$5/9 \approx 0.5556$
Recall	$3/6 = 0.50$	$5/6 \approx 0.8333$

Accuracy divides all correct predictions by 20. Precision divides the found updates by all predicted updates; recall divides them by all six real updates. The denominators describe different populations.
Multiply each error count by its cost:

$$C_A = 3c_{\text{miss}} + c_{\text{false}}, \qquad C_B = c_{\text{miss}} + 4c_{\text{false}}.$$

B saves two misses while adding three false alarms. Therefore $C_B < C_A$ exactly when $2c_{\text{miss}} > 3c_{\text{false}}$, or $c_{\text{miss}}/c_{\text{false}} > 3/2$. They tie at $3/2$; A costs less below it. With costs 4 and 1, A costs 13 units and B costs 8. B can have lower accuracy and still be preferable for the stated error costs.

3. Make two reliability points

Keep every score paired with its label. The lower bin contains scores $(0.1, 0.2, 0.4)$ and labels $(0, 1, 0)$, so its point is $(0.7/3, 1/3) = (7/30, 1/3) \approx (0.2333, 0.3333)$. The upper bin contains scores $(0.6, 0.8, 0.9)$ and labels $(1, 1, 0)$, giving $(2.3/3, 2/3) = (23/30, 2/3) \approx (0.7667, 0.6667)$. The upper bin has a mean score above its observed positive rate.

For the binary Brier score, square the error on each original message before averaging. The six squared errors are $(0.01, 0.64, 0.16, 0.16, 0.04, 0.81)$:

$$\text{Brier} = \frac{1.82}{6} \approx 0.3033.$$

A constant probability of 0.5 incurs error 0.25 on every example, so its score is 0.25, which is lower. Three of the six labels are positive, so the constant predictor also has a single empirical reliability point at $(0.5, 0.5)$. It matches the overall frequency but does not distinguish any cases.

Using UPDATE for scores at least 0.5, the original scores give four correct labels out of six; the constant predictor gives three. Better label accuracy and better probability quality need not pick the same model. These six cases illustrate the arithmetic; they cannot establish calibration on future traffic.

4. Resample paired outcomes

The original differences are $(0, 1, 1, -1, 0)$, whose mean is $1/5 = 0.20$. The one-based IDs $(2, 2, 4, 5, 1)$ select differences $(1, 1, -1, 0, 0)$, also with mean $1/5$. Their equality is a coincidence of this particular draw. Duplicates must repeat both models' outcomes on the same example.

Separate lists destroy the comparison on shared examples. If A and B make identical predictions, a paired resample always has gap zero. Independent lists could give B five easy cases and A five hard cases and produce an apparent gap of 1 despite their identical predictions. A paired draw preserves this dependence and the exact cancellation when the systems agree.

5. Turn probabilities into decisions

Predicting UPDATE risks a false alarm when the message is really a lookup. At $p = 0.3$, that expected cost is $1(1 - 0.3) = 0.7$. Predicting LOOKUP risks a missed update, with expected cost $4(0.3) = 1.2$. Choose UPDATE, even though UPDATE is the less probable class.

For general positive costs, compare the two expectations and solve for p:

$$c_{\text{false}}(1 - p) < c_{\text{miss}}p \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad p > \frac{c_{\text{false}}}{c_{\text{false}} + c_{\text{miss}}}.$$

The threshold is $1/(1 + 4) = 0.2$. At equality, both actions cost 0.8 in expectation. One valid tie rule is to choose UPDATE when $p \geq 0.2$; record that convention. The derivation assumes correct decisions cost zero and that the probabilities and constant error costs describe the target population. Calibration within coarse bins alone does not verify these assumptions for every input.

Use validation predictions to fit a calibration mapping or tune a threshold. Freeze these choices before evaluating the test set. If validation cases are reused repeatedly to tune many choices, account for that selection, for example with additional held-out validation data. Changing deployment conditions can require fresh validation; the arithmetic does not guarantee stable costs or probabilities.

6. Check a split by group

Suppose each row is a message and its group ID identifies the customer who sent it. Customer 1 sent the first two messages. If those messages go into different splits, the model can learn customer-specific patterns in training and encounter them again during evaluation. To evaluate on held-out customers, assign each customer to one split and send all of that customer's rows there.

The eight rows have group IDs $(1, 1, 2, 3, 3, 4, 5, 5)$, so there are five distinct groups. Give `split_by_group` the group counts $(3, 1, 1)$ for train, validation, and test, with seed 7. The helper shuffles the distinct IDs and takes the first three for train, the next one for validation, and the last one for test. It then finds the original row indices for the IDs in each split.

Train gets groups $\{1, 3, 5\}$, validation gets $\{2\}$, and test gets $\{4\}$. The row indices start at zero. In train, rows 0 and 1 belong to group 1, rows 3 and 4 to group 3, and rows 6 and 7 to group 5. The seeded order sets membership. The returned rows appear in their original order.

Each of the three train groups supplies two rows, giving six training rows. The validation and test groups each supply one row. Thus the split has group counts $(3, 1, 1)$ and row counts $(6, 1, 1)$. A quota in groups gives a row count that depends on the sizes of the selected groups.

7. Inspect an empty bin

Imagine four messages scored for whether they are updates. The scores 0 and 0.1 belong to messages that are lookups (label 0). The scores 0.9 and 1 belong to updates (label 1). We want to compare the scores with how often updates actually occur among messages with similar scores.

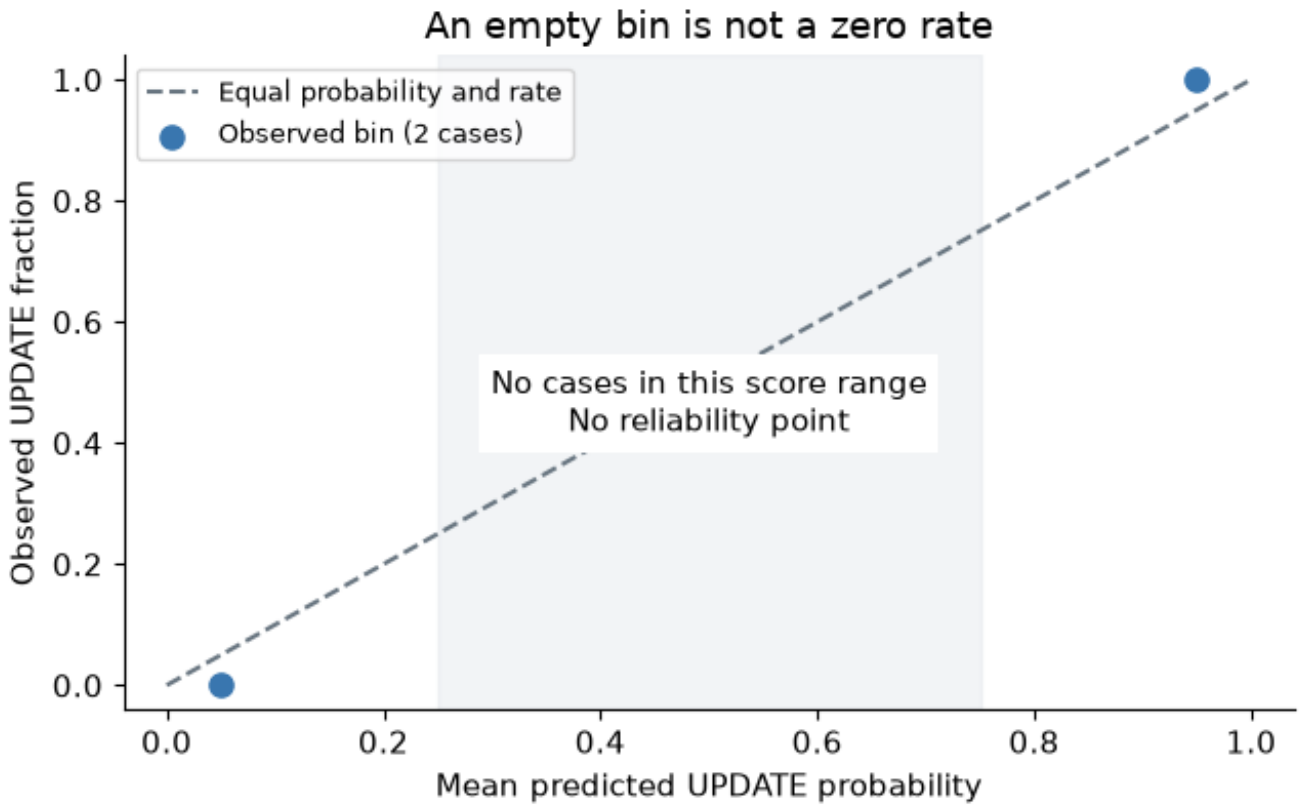
Use edges $(0, 0.25, 0.75, 1)$. Each bin includes its left edge and excludes its right edge, with one exception. The last bin also includes 1, so every valid probability belongs to a bin. A score exactly equal to 0.25 goes in the middle bin, and a score exactly equal to 0.75 goes in the last bin.
A reliability plot puts the mean predicted probability on the horizontal axis and the fraction of positive labels on the vertical axis. Use the bins whose counts are positive.

Bin	Scores	Mean probability	Positive fraction	Plot point
$[0, 0.25)$	$0, 0.1$	$(0 + 0.1)/2 = 0.05$	$0/2 = 0$	$(0.05, 0)$
$[0.25, 0.75)$	None	Undefined	Undefined	Omit
$[0.75, 1]$	$0.9, 1$	$(0.9 + 1)/2 = 0.95$	$2/2 = 1$	$(0.95, 1)$

The low bin is 0.05 below the ideal diagonal $y = x$ because the mean score exceeds the observed fraction. The high bin is 0.05 above it because the observed fraction exceeds the mean score. Each point summarizes two examples.

In the middle bin, both averages would require dividing by zero. The helper returns `NaN` for both coordinates to mark them as undefined. Filling both with zero would draw a fake perfectly calibrated point at $(0, 0)$. Plotting a zero rate at the bin midpoint, $(0.50, 0)$, would instead suggest that predictions near 0.50 all had negative outcomes. The data contain no examples in that range. The low bin's zero rate is a measured $0/2$, whereas the middle bin's count of zero means its rate is undefined.

The helper also returns the Brier score. It averages the squared error between each original score and its label. Here the errors are 0, 0.01, 0.01, and 0, so the Brier score is $0.02/4 = 0.005$.



8. Change the resampling unit

Models A and B label the same six messages. The first customer sent two messages, and B gets both right where A gets both wrong. The last customer sent one message that only A gets right and one that both models get right. The table keeps the two predictions together for each message.

Message	Customer	True label	A	B	Correctness difference
1	0	1	0	1	+1
2	0	1	0	1	+1
3	1	0	0	0	0
4	1	0	1	1	0
5	2	1	1	0	−1
6	2	0	0	0	0

On message i, the correctness difference d_i is 1 if only B is right, -1 if only A is right, and 0 if both have the same outcome. The difference in accuracy is the average of these row differences. A gets three messages right and B gets four, so the observed gap is

$$\Delta = \frac{4}{6} - \frac{3}{6} = \frac{1+1+0+0-1+0}{6} = \frac{1}{6}.$$

A paired bootstrap repeatedly draws a new sample, allowing repeats, from the observed test set. A row draw keeps A, B, and the true label together. For example, drawing messages 1, 1, 2, 4, 5, and 6 gives a gap of $(1+1+1+0-1+0)/6 = 1/3$ for that draw.

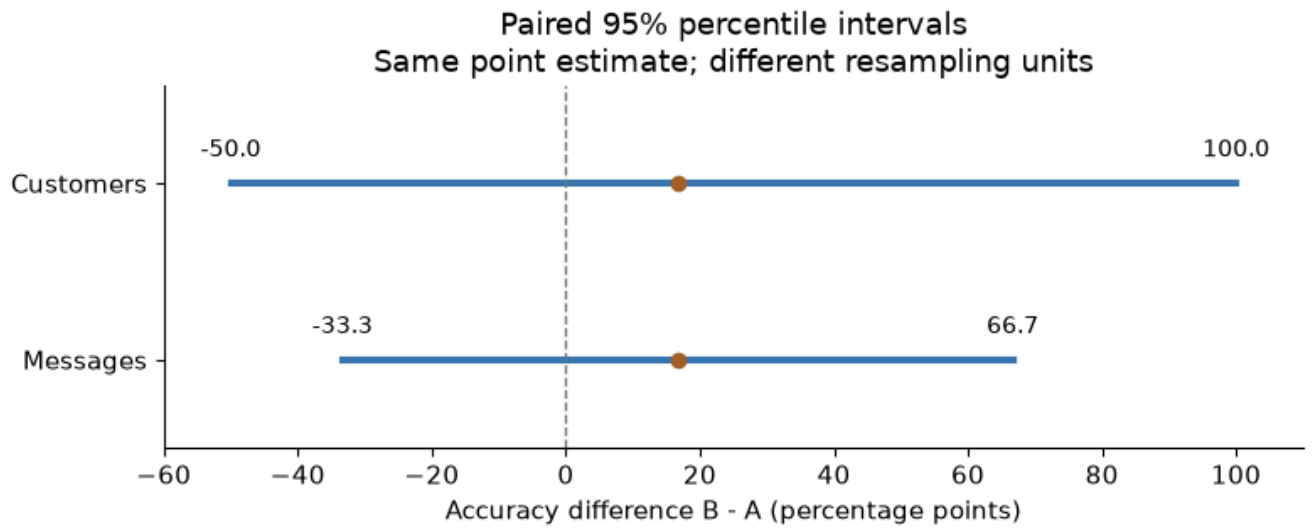
With customer resampling, each draw selects three customers and brings along every message from each selected customer. For example, drawing customers 0, 0, and 2 contributes two copies of customer 0's gain of two correct messages and one copy of customer 2's loss of one. The gap is $(2 + 2 - 1)/6 = 1/2$. The denominator counts all sampled messages, including repeats. This gives each sampled message equal weight even if customers have different message counts.

Compute 4,000 resampled gaps for each method with seed 5. The 95% percentile interval uses the 2.5th and 97.5th percentiles of those gaps. Both calls report the same observed gap because they score the same original six messages.

Both methods estimate a gain of 16.7 percentage points for B on these six messages. The interval widens from $[-1/3, 2/3]$ for messages to $[-1/2, 1]$ for customers. With customer resampling, the first customer's two gains always travel together. A draw with three copies of that customer has a gap of $+1$. A draw with three copies of the last customer has a gap of $-1/2$.

Use the customer bootstrap when messages from a customer can be dependent and customers are the independent units. For example, two messages may use the same wording or discuss the same request. Drawing customers preserves these connections. Both intervals span zero and allow sizable changes in either direction. Six messages from just three customers give little information about the gap for new customers. These intervals describe sensitivity to the evaluation sample for the two fixed checkpoints. To study variation across training runs, compare independently trained checkpoints.

The intervals are approximate percentile summaries, especially fragile with only three independent customers. Their inclusion of zero does not prove that A and B are equivalent: they permit substantial gains and losses. Increasing the 4,000 draws would reduce simulation noise in the percentiles but would not add independent customers. The nominal 95% level is a repeated-sampling coverage target, not a posterior probability that the fixed gap lies in this particular interval.



For the separate unequal-customer example, U contributes one row with difference $+1$. V contributes three rows whose differences sum to -2 and average $-2/3$. The per-message gap is $(1 - 2)/(1 + 3) = -1/4$, favoring A. The equal-customer gap is $(1 - 2/3)/2 = 1/6$, favoring B. Changing the weighting changes the question.

For the sampled customer list (U, U), include U's one message twice. The per-message numerator is $1 + 1 = 2$, the denominator is $1 + 1 = 2$, and the gap is 1. For (U, V) they are -1 and 4, giving $-1/4$; for (V, V) they are -4 and 6, giving $-2/3$. Divide by the sampled message count, which need not stay fixed when group sizes differ. The helper's grouped option retains this per-message target.

9. Audit a prediction join (optional)

Suppose the reference file has one row per message and the prediction file contains the same six messages in a different order. For `m01`, the correct label is 1 and the model's prediction is also 1. In the shuffled file the first row belongs to `m04` and predicts 0. Scoring by position treats that 0 as a mistake on `m01`.

An example ID is a stable key for a message across both files. Keep the IDs attached while shuffling the prediction records. First score the values in their current order to see what happens when the keys are ignored.

Both arrays have six values, so `binary_metrics` can compute an accuracy even when the rows represent different messages. Before scoring, check for a one-to-one match. Build an index for each file, rejecting repeated IDs before a dictionary assignment can overwrite a row. Then compare the key sets in both directions. A reference key absent from predictions is missing. A prediction key absent from the reference is unexpected. Once the keys agree, look up every prediction in the order of the reference IDs.

The row-order calculation reports two correct answers out of six. The ID join recovers four correct answers out of six. Try three broken prediction files to check that they are rejected before scoring. A replacement with an unexpected ID or a duplicate can leave the file with all six rows, so checking the count alone misses both errors.

This check also rejects duplicate keys in the reference file. For a paired model comparison, run the same check for each model's file against the same reference order before passing the two arrays to the bootstrap helper.

10. Separate length from evidence placement (optional)

Ask for the invoice number for order P27. One report sentence says: *The total for order P27 was settled under invoice IN-843.* Other orders can have plausible invoice numbers, but only this sentence answers the question. Score exact invoice match after a fixed normalization such as trimming whitespace.
Use report-body lengths of 512, 2,048, and 8,192 tokens, with evidence starts near 10%, 50%, and 90%. Here a token position is a zero-based index. For a worked layout, suppose the evidence occupies 16 tokens and set its start to $\lfloor fL \rfloor$, where L is the body length and f the chosen fraction. The question starts at $q = L$ in these body-relative coordinates. The distance from the exclusive evidence end to the question is $L - \lfloor fL \rfloor - 16$.

Body tokens	Early: start / distance	Middle: start / distance	Late: start / distance
512	51 / 445	256 / 240	460 / 36
2,048	204 / 1,828	1,024 / 1,008	1,843 / 189
8,192	819 / 7,357	4,096 / 4,080	7,372 / 804

Within a row, keep the body length, question, answer, evidence wording, scoring rule, and distractor inventory fixed. Reserve neutral spans and swap the evidence with an equal-token-length span, leaving distractors in place. Re-tokenize the complete formatted prompt and check the lengths and boundaries: raw-text swaps do not guarantee identical token counts. Keep instructions fixed and reserve generation capacity after including the question and any wrappers. The 16-token span is a layout assumption, not a claim about a specific tokenizer.

For the second experiment, hold exactly 128 tokens between the evidence end and the question. With the same 16-token evidence span, set its start to $L - 128 - 16$. The starts are 368, 1,904, and 8,048; the exclusive ends are 384, 1,920, and 8,064. The distance is 128 in every case. Insert additional neutral text before the evidence as the body grows and preserve the suffix after it. Hold the distractor inventory fixed or explicitly exclude candidate invoice numbers from the added filler.

Use many underlying reports, vary the correct invoice numbers, and compare placements on matched reports. Split and resample whole report families, including their placement variants. Report exact positions, counts per condition, and failed or truncated inputs. If a model cannot accept a complete prompt, state the unsupported condition rather than silently dropping or shortening it. Synthetic retrieval results should be supplemented with realistic reports.

11. Test one change at a time (optional)

The supported released-system claim is that the measured configuration of B has lower response latency than A on the stated workload, device, and software. Mixer, training data, precision, implementation, and their interactions all contribute. The result does not isolate the mixer. Quality must also be measured; a faster system that answers a different task or stops early is not automatically preferable.

For a mixer ablation, build two variants of one model. Keep tokenizer, input format, training and validation data, training-token count, optimizer policy, prediction interface, and checkpoint selection rule fixed. Preserve stack depth, residual width, feed-forward blocks, and output head. Replace the designated mixer layers. Choose a matching budget, such as model width and training tokens, and report remaining parameter or compute differences. Give both variants comparable validation tuning effort; identical learning rates need not be equally suitable. Use the same declared seed set for multiple runs. Matching seeds is a control, not proof that different architectures experience identical randomness.

Measure quality on the same examples, including task accuracy, error types, paired test-sample uncertainty and variation across training runs separately. For latency, keep device, software, batch size, precision, prompts, and decoding policy fixed. Warm up, synchronize the relevant device around timed regions, alternate run order, and report distributions across repeated trials. Separate time to first token, time per later decoding step, throughput, and end-to-end latency. Prefill time alone is not user-facing time to first token.

For a controlled timing diagnostic, feed a fixed continuation token sequence to both models so output length and tokens are matched; report this as a teacher-forced timing experiment. Also time actual generation under a declared stopping rule for the deployment result. Use several prompt lengths if storage or computation is expected to scale with history.

Count live key/value arrays and recurrent or convolutional states that persist between steps. Separately report reserved capacity, model-weight bytes, and peak temporary workspace. A smaller persistent history need not mean a smaller peak or a faster system. The ablation supports a claim about this mixer change under these controls; the released packages remain a separate systems comparison.

12. Design a reproducibility check (optional)

Two aggregate scores do not reveal which cases each system got right. Start with the versioned dataset, labeled evaluation rows, and saved split manifest. For every row, require a stable example ID, its group or connected-family ID, and assigned split. Record exclusions, provenance, the unit scored, and which data selected hyperparameters, thresholds, prompts, and checkpoints. Check that the grouping constraints are disjoint across splits and the test rows match the frozen manifest. Fine-tuning splits alone cannot rule out pretraining exposure.

Request one raw and parsed prediction per model per example, the class order, score meaning, decoding settings, threshold, and normalization or parsing rules. Specify how invalid and missing predictions count. Check unique IDs, exact key coverage, and the mapping back to gold labels before joining by ID. Replay parsing and recompute each accuracy, confusion counts, and the difference. Equal array lengths alone cannot validate the join.

For the paired interval, form B's correctness minus A's on each matched row. Resample the same rows for both models or draw independent source groups and include all their rows. Keep the metric's denominator consistent with the target: a per-message gap divides by the sampled message count, including repeats. Save the resampling unit, confidence level, seed, draw count, and quantile convention. Nonlinear metrics require recomputation on each draw. Record both the number of rows and the number and sizes of independent groups.

Variation across training runs needs separately trained checkpoints and their per-example predictions, along with initialization/data-order seeds, training recipes, model revisions, and validation-based selection rules. Evaluate all declared runs on the same test manifest and report the rule used to summarize them. The spread across runs and the bootstrap for one fixed pair of checkpoints answer separate questions. A saved bootstrap seed cannot reproduce a training run.

The small check here reuses the audited ID join from Exercise 9. It returns the same $4/6$ accuracy, verifies that group IDs remain disjoint across the Exercise 6 splits, and confirms that comparing the same predictions to themselves gives an exactly zero point and interval. These are useful integrity checks; they do not replace the requested source files or validate the population sampling.